

JLPT N4 - The look-alikes that decide pass/fail

6 traps N4 actually tests + the one-line tell that breaks each

This free sample is a slice of the full **JLPT N4 Exam Prep - by Section** guide. N4 rarely tests whether you know a form - it tests whether you can tell two look-alikes apart fast. So instead of one more grammar list, here are six confusions N4 actually tests, each with the one-line tell that breaks it, then five questions that hit them. No sign-up needed; keep this PDF.

Six look-alikes N4 actually tests

Confusion	The tell (what breaks it)	Correct contrast
たら / と / なら / ば	と = automatic result, NO request/command after; たら = if/when (can take a request); なら = advice on a topic; ば = general condition	春になると さく。駅に 着いたら 電話して。行くなら 京都。安ければ 買う。
Passive / Potential ～(ら)れる	Passive has a doer marked by に ("done to me"); potential takes が ("can")	母に しかられた (passive). かんじが 読める (potential).
looks-like / hearsay ～そう	looks = from sight, joins the masu-stem; hearsay = "I heard", joins the plain form	雨が ふりそう (looks). 雨が ふるそう (I heard).
～ている (state vs action)	With change verbs, ている = resulting STATE, not an action in progress	結婚して います = is married. 食べて います = is eating.
self vs. someone (自他)	Intransitive: が + happens by itself; transitive: を + someone does it	ドアが あく (it opens). ドアを あける (I open it).
まだ / もう	まだ + negative = not yet; もう + past = already; もう + negative = not anymore	まだ 食べて いない。もう 食べた。

Try 5 - each targets one trap above (answers below)

- この ボタンを おすと、きっぷが ()。 [たら/と]
① 出てください ② 出よう ③ 出ます ④ 出たい
- わたしは ピアノが ()。 [passive/potential]
① ひけます ② ひかれます ③ ひかせます ④ ひきます
- てんきよほうによると、たいふうが () そうです。 [hearsay そう]
① きそう ② きた ③ き ④ くる
- 田中さんを知っていますか。— はい、 ()。 [ている state]
① 知ります ② 知っています ③ 知ってあります ④ 知りました
- まどが ()。さむいですから しめましょう。 [自他]
① あけています ② あいています ③ しめています ④ あけました

Answer key

- ③ **出ます** と = automatic result; it cannot take a request/volition after it - only 出ます works.
- ① **ひけます** 'can play' = potential ひける (object takes が). ひかれます is passive 'is played'.
- ④ **くる** Hearsay ～そう joins the PLAIN form: くる + そう. きそう would be the looks-like form.
- ② **知っています** 'To know' works only as a state: 知っています. Plain 知ります is not used for the present - you never say it to mean 'I know'; the negative is 知りません.
- ② **あいています** The window IS open (intransitive state) = あいています. あけています = someone is in the act of opening it.

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